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ERRATA

Page 10, 8th line from bottom:
For "are compressed" *read* "expand"
Page 11, 4th line from top:
For "become warm and expand" *read* "be compressed and warmed"

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March 14, The Art of the Nomad, by Mrs. Dagny Carter.[2]

March 22, The Ruins of Ankor,[2] by Mr. R. Vivian Dent.

May 3, Bamboo and Bamboo Painting, by Mr. Teng Kuei.[1]

May 10, The Mahayana Buddhism,[2] by Prof. D. T. Suzuki, probably the greatest living authority on the subject.

The final lecture of the session was on May 17, by Dr. Florence Ayscough, her subject being The Connection Between Chinese Calligraphy, Poetry and Painting.[2]

It will be observed that the lectures covered a variety of subjects, and that the lecturers included nationals of America, Britain, China, Germany and Japan, exemplifying the mutual interest of those who meet on the cultural ground of the Society and demonstrating the truth of the statement that learning knows no nationality and often turns to fruitful yield contacts which in other spheres of activity are only too frequently the potential points of friction.

The attendance at the lectures naturally varied with the degree of popularity of the subject. It is therefore difficult to generalise and say that attendances were good or bad. If, however, attendances are to be measured by the seating capacity of this hall, one has to admit that a number of lectures deserved better support that they received.

Membership: During the year 64 new members were elected and 30 resigned; I regret to have to report the death of 10 others. The net increase in membership was therefore 24. The roll of membership shows 719 names, but of this number 110 are delinquent in the payment of annual dues since 1931 and the majority probably consider themselves as having resigned. In addition there are over 120 members whose subscriptions for the year just ended are outstanding, so that the actual active membership is about 500—representing a support quite incapable of maintaining the activities of the Society as visualised by those responsible for the erection of this building.

Museum: On Wednesday, November 15, 1933, Mr. A. D. Bell, the Chairman of the Shanghai Municipal

[2] See section in this *Journal* "Summaries of Lectures."

BAMBOO AND BAMBOO PAINTING

By TENG KUEI, M.F.A., F.R.S.A.

The history of bamboo in China dates as far back as that of the Chinese race and civilization. Its extensive usefulness in daily life well matches its inspiring influence in intellectual circles—indeed, it is so useful and so inspiring that it has become inseparate from Chinese life. Its shoots are eaten; rafts, furniture, kitchen utensils, toys for the young and walking sticks for the old, weapons for soldiers, baskets for merchants and women, books, paper, penholders for men of letters, and instruments for musicians—all are made from bamboo. It is said that Shên Nung 神農 (? 2737 B.C.), the prehistoric emperor, used it as medicine. Documentary records were said to have been inscribed on bamboo tablets as early as the legendary reign of Huang Ti 黃帝 (? 2697 B.C.)—such as the law books, "the greater seal characters" of Shih Liu 史籀 (800 B.C.), the histographer of the Chou Dynasty. Every day and everywhere in China we are in contact with bamboo in its various forms.

Its great service in practical life so impressed the intellectual classes that they came to love it, respect it and idealize it. They have seen something beautiful and abiding beyond its material form, something quite akin to their own spirit and taste; they have attributed to it some of the ideal virtues of man and have addressed it as a teacher, a gentleman, a friend. "I cannot get along without this gentleman (meaning bamboo) even for a single day," said Wang Wei-chih 王徽之 son of Wang Hsi-chih 王羲之 (A.D. 321-379), the father of Chinese calligraphy, whose writing about the famous gathering of the scholars in the bamboo forest around the Orchid Pavilion is still copied by present day scholars for practice in calligraphy. The three friends in winter are

the pine, the bamboo and the plum; and the four gentlemen are the plum, the orchid, the bamboo and the chrysanthemum. Every Chinese knows something about them; every poet writes about them and every artist paints them. Wang Wei's little quatrain on the bamboo reads:

"Alone I sit in the tranquil bamboo forest
Sweeping the strings and shouting long and loud;
The forest is deep; no one knows my presence,
But the bright moon comes to shine upon me."[1]

In short, its strong, enduring nature serves as a symbol of perseverance; its perfectly straight body as a symbol of uprightness; its empty, tube-like stem a symbol of capacity and humility; its tough joints a symbol of chastity and firmness; and its wavering, rustling leaves a symbol of sweet melancholy.

Notwithstanding its importance in practical life and its influence over the intellectual, its chief inspiration lies in the world of painting, for here it not only serves as an independent subject, but also as a link between calligraphy and painting, and as the point of departure from the ancient and mediaeval, elaborate brush painting to that of the idealistic school which still flourishes in modern times. In order to make this clear I shall briefly trace the history of Chinese painting.

Roughly speaking, Chinese painting before the T'ang Dynasty (A.D. 618-905) was realistic in nature, realistic in the sense of a faithful and exhaustive registering of the facts of nature, and utilitarian in purpose. Just because it was utilitarian in purpose so it was realistic in nature. And painting was mostly by artisans (by very few real artists), though of the most marvelous order because of the strong encouragement outside and their own eagerness and sincerity in dealing with their subjects. For this reason, though great they were (as Ku K'ai-chih's roll in the British Museum for example), they lacked variety and power of stroke in the genuine calligraphic sense. Consequently the beauty of the ink was not found as in later painters. In other words, the canons of calligraphic writing were not applied to painting until the coming of the T'ang masters.

The advent of the T'ang Dynasty brought with it a new school of painting, the school of idealism which

[1] 獨坐幽篁裏 彈琴復長嘯 深林人不知 明月來相照



Finger Painting of Bamboo by Teng Kuei

reached its height in the Sung (A.D. 960-1280) and Yüan Dynasties (A.D. 1280-1368). The T'ang Dynasty at its height formed a period of expansion. Political and military triumphs together with societal prosperity widened views of life, encouraged hope, gave leisure to ponder over the charm and value of things as such, and aroused a zeal for initiative and adventure. The influence of *Zen* (*Ch'an*) Buddhism as well as Taoism widened the scope of imagination. The masters, under such influences, succeeded in achieving something new by a wide and powerful fusion of both the past and the present, the objective and the subjective, the balanced and the reticent with the eccentric and the expressive.

This new idea in painting naturally called for a new way of expression, and it so happened that these masters excelled in many fields, in poetry, scholarship and especially in calligraphy, so they applied all the principles of writing to painting, and the so-called "Ink Painting" thus developed. Ink painting made possible not only variety of strokes but also gradation of ink values or shades and tone qualities.

Among all the subjects these masters painted, bamboo serves as the best illustration, for the reason that it requires the steadiest wrist, the most firm and balanced control of the brush to paint successfully its long, straight yet jointed body and its flat, knife-like leaves. In painting bamboo no painter can hide a feeble hand, a wavering brush or lazy stroke, for its peculiar nature frankly tells everything and strikingly reveals every trick. Only the most powerful masters can paint bamboo with success, and no painter can be called a master of the idealist school unless he can paint bamboo well. It is the starting point as well as the final triumph for an idealist.

Aside from these technical requirements of bamboo painting, its mastery is also an essential part in the formation of ideas which are called vision. By vision here is meant not only the concentrated vizualization of the subject for the artist's particular picture, but also his own view or idealization of it and his own mood under such circumstances. In any other painting, such as a landscape or even figures, the painter may proceed with a general conception in his mind and work out its composition and the details as he goes on, but with bamboo he cannot well do this because of its previously mentioned peculiarities; otherwise there will be signs of hesitation, hints of jarring moods and wandering

thoughts, and complete failure will result. Thus we may say that through bamboo painting with ink we are able to attain a better understanding of the psychological conditions under which the art is produced than in any other branch of Chinese art. We may also say that bamboo, being the chief representative of both the technical as well as the idealistic sides of this new school, represents a further step from ancient and mediaeval painting to that of modern times. For it has been the connecting link between calligraphy and painting, as well as the point of departure from mere artistic painting to that of personality and scholarly expression which may be rightly claimed as truly representative of the genius of Chinese art.

Coming to the painting of bamboo itself, a few points are to be made clear. First, who originally painted bamboo as an independent subject? Second, who first painted "ink bamboo"? Third, what are the technical secrets of ink bamboo painting? Finally, who are the masters of ink bamboo painting?

Madame Li 李夫人 of the later T'ang Dynasty is generally known as the original painter of ink bamboo. She earnestly studied the shadows of the bamboo wavering on the window screens under the moonlight. But according to the *Hua Shih Hui Chuan* 畫史彙傳 written by P'ên Wên-ts'an 彭蘊燦, Kuan Yü 關羽 the adopted brother of Liu Pei 劉備 Emperor of Shu Han 蜀漢 (third century A.D.) was the first painter of bamboo, and his paintings were later engraved on stone tablets. Between these two painters there were many other bamboo painters such as the great T'ang masters Wu Tao-tzŭ 吳道子 and Wang Wei 王維. However, none of them painted bamboo as an independent subject. The earliest artist who thus painted it as an independent subject was Wên T'ung 文同 of the Sung Dynasty (d. 1079). He was also the first to paint bamboo in ink. The masters before Wên T'ung did not paint with such definite technique as is called ink painting. They treated bamboo as they would treat any other plant, utilizing massive foliage to fill in the backgrounds of their landscapes; the features of the figures are not finely studied in their detailed exquisiteness.

Bamboo may be painted in double outline with color or without color but so far as technique is concerned, neither of these styles is as difficult to paint as ink painting; nor do these styles show as powerful strokes

and as ideal images as ink painting. The ink paintings of bamboo make use of nearly all the eight brush canons of calligraphy and the five values of ink. Unlike color painting of bamboo, which is an endeavor to attain the balance and contrast between different colors, ink painting is a triumph of writing of thought and coloring in monochrome.

Painters of ink bamboo are numerous, but a few of the greatest who may be discussed here are Wên T'ung 文同, Su Tung-p'o 蘇東坡 of the Sung Dynasty (A.D. 930-1278), Wu Chên 吳鎮, Fu Kuang 傅光, Ko Chiu-ssŭ 柯九思, and the wife of Chao Mêng-fu, Kuan Chung-chi 管仲姬 (1260-1333) of the Yüan Dynasty. Wang Fu, 王紱 (1362-1416), Wên Chêng-ming 文徵明, Madame Ma Hsiang-lan 馬湘蘭 of the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644), Tao Chien 道濟, Shên Nan-ping 沈南蘋, and Chêng Pan-ch'iao 鄭板橋 of the Ch'ing Dynasty (1644-1912).

Wên T'ung, a native of Szechuan, practiced penmanship for ten years but still failed to understand the secret of writing. One day this secret was suddenly revealed to him as he watched two snakes fighting by the wayside. His bamboo exhibits the dynamic quality of nature; the charm and motion in his pictures often convey to us strongly the wind blown effect.

Su Tung-p'o (1036-1101) learned his art from his friend, Wên T'ung, but on account of his different background in calligraphy he created a style of his own. His strokes have a dashing and sweeping quality, together with a restful mood, a fresh breath of life. He used a comparatively soft brush but with a very deft hand. He has a fine representation of ink values.

The Yüan Dynasty marked the zenith in ink bamboo painting on account of the widened scope of brush strokes and technical power brought into painting by its masters. Wu Chên (1280-1354), with his superior skill in "speed writing," crowned the glory of the Yüan Dynasty. The brush under the direction of his hand was transformed, as it were, into a sharp crusading sword; nothing could check the full sway of its freedom. It was like a storm come suddenly with unlimited force, crushing everything in its way.

Ko Chiu-ssŭ, a great master of the Yüan Dynasty, was also a great scholar. He wrote a treatise on ink bamboo painting which was the second book published in this line in Chinese art history. He applied *Li Shu* 隸書 and *K'ai Shu* 楷書 technique in painting bamboo, and his

power, like that of Wu Chên, came from the sway of the whole arm instead of the wrist.

Fu Kuang, a monk originally of Shansi Province, studied the style of Wên T'ung, but in addition he brought forth the realistic texture of the bamboo and made the subject of his picture even more intimate to his audience. But the real difference between the paintings of his teacher and those by himself is in the same category as the difference between Greek sculpture and that of Rome.

I cannot leave the Yüan Dynasty without mentioning Madame Chao Mêng-fu, still better known as Madame Kuan Tao-shan [Kuan Chung-chi]. Being a woman she naturally paints more with feeling than knowledge, with a pure heart rather than with intellect. Her work is full of rhythm and beauty which should be felt rather than studied.

The Ming Dynasty (1368-1644) was generally known as the post-renaissance in Chinese art, and bamboo painting was no exception. The greatest Ming masters were Wang Fu (1362-1416) and Wên Chêng-ming. They brought back the Sung refinement to their brush. But the too reserved discipline of Ming masters under the influence of the Confucian idea of a law abiding society, made them somewhat timid and lacking in freedom in comparison with the masters of the previous Dynasties who drew their inspiration from Buddhism and Taoism. The brush of Wên Chêng-ming deserves the same criticism as the other masters of the Ming Dynasty. The exception is one girl artist who lived a different life and held to a philosophy different from all the others. She was highly gifted and well educated but unfortunately she led a Bohemian life and the sufferings experienced by herself and observed by others made her art sadly indignant to the world without. Her strokes are charming and sweet but at the same time hold innate dignity.

Students of Chinese art are easily convinced that the polychromic landscapes of the Ch'ing Dynasty (1644-1912) are inferior to those of the Ming, but in the field of ink painting, especially in the paintings of bamboo, a certain technical beauty and freedom is revealed. The brush of Shên Nan-ping (*f.* 1731) is at its best in ink paintings; the naturalism and charm of the bamboo are finely portrayed. His bamboo is a typical product of the technique of *K'ai* (regular) and *Hsing* (running) calligraphy.

Chêng Pan-ch'iao, also a poet and calligrapher, was the great romantic scholar of the Ch'ing Dynasty. Although he once accepted an official post in Shantung, he was in his soul a Taoist and follower of the philosophy of Chuang Tzŭ. His bamboo retains a perfect, natural poise and freedom although he cannot free himself from formulas by which most Ming masters imprison themselves.

Those artists who resented or were indifferent to the rule of the Manchus became more attached to Buddhistic and Taoistic ideals. They thus strove for freedom, and freedom in art expression proved to be better and easier to attain than freedom of speech or writing. Ink bamboo offered them the best opportunity. Thus the brush of Tao Chien, better known as Monk Shih Tao 石濤和尙, was acclaimed the most powerful south of the Yangtse River. Bamboo stems painted by his brush have a tactile feeling and three dimensional quality.

From all these masterpieces we see the general tendency moving from the refinement and imagination of the Sung masters to the powerful calligraphic expressionism of the Yüan masters, and from the conservative copying of Sung refinement of the Ming to the charm and romantic freedom of the masters of the Ch'ing Dynasty.